

THE REPLY LADDER

The cold outreach system that takes a stranger from first message, to reply, to qualified conversation, to booked call.

SMS / DM / EMAIL / FOLLOW-UP / THE CALL

Licensed to: _____

Phone: _____

Read this first

This is not a swipe file. A swipe file hands you words and leaves you guessing when to use them. This is a ladder: seven rungs, and every message in this book belongs to one of them. You always know where a conversation is and what the next message has to do.

Three rules before you open anything else.

1. Ten messages today beats reading all of this tonight

Do not read this cover to cover and start on Monday. Open Module 01, pick the sequence that matches whether you have results yet, and send ten messages before you close this file. You will learn more from ten replies than from another hour of reading.

2. The proof in these scripts is mine. Replace it with yours.

Several scripts reference specific results: a pool builder in Sarasota, appointments booked in Phoenix, a client adding signed contracts. Those are my numbers, from my clients. They are in here so you can see the shape of a proof-led message, not so you can send them.

DO NOT DO THIS Sending someone else's case study as your own is fabricating proof. It is dishonest, it destroys you the moment one prospect checks, and in most places it is also illegal advertising. Every bracketed proof claim in this book is a blank for your own result. If you have no result yet, use the no-proof track in Module 01, which is built precisely for that situation.

3. Six to seven follow-ups is the job

Most people send one message and conclude that outreach does not work. The replies are in touches two through six. Alex Hormozi's rule of thumb is that it is fair to follow up six or seven times before you part ways, and every sequence in this book is built on that. If you are not willing to do that, nothing else in here will help you.

The ladder, on one page

Seven rungs. Every script in this book is tagged to one of them.

- 01 Prospect** Who you contact, and how you build the list. Module 00.
- 02 Opening message** One job: earn a reply. Not sell, not introduce yourself, not book anything. Modules 01 to 03.
- 03 Reply** Four types of reply, four different responses. Module 04.
- 04 Qualification** Two or three questions that prove you know the trade and tell you if this is real. Module 04.
- 05 Follow-up** Touches two through seven. Where most of your replies actually come from. Module 04.
- 06 Booked call** Moving from thread to calendar without the "let me know what suits" loop. Module 05.
- 07 The conversation** Pre-call commitment, the call itself, no-show recovery. Module 05.

Module 00 / Before you send anything

Four things decide whether your outreach works, and all four happen before you type a single message.

Pick one niche and stay in it

One niche gives you one reply rate, one set of qualification questions, and one case study that compounds. Five niches give you noise and no idea what is failing. The scripts in this book use pool builders and home service contractors as the worked example because that is the market I run. Swap the trade, keep the structure.

Your offer decides your opening message

There are two tracks in this book, and which one you use depends entirely on one question: do you have a result you can point to?

Track A: you have results

Lead with the result and the market. The message is short, it names a specific place and a specific number, and it ends in a question about capacity. This is Module 01, Sequence A.

Track B: you have no results yet

Do not fake one. Instead, remove the risk entirely and make the offer itself the hook. Pay per in-home appointment, or pay per job. You only get paid when they get something real.

This is a genuinely strong position and you should not be embarrassed by it. A contractor who has been burned by three agencies on retainer will take a performance offer from a nobody over a retainer pitch from somebody. Your lack of a case study is exactly why your offer can be better than theirs.

WHY IT WORKS A low risk offer replaces proof. If they cannot lose money, they do not need evidence that you will not lose it for them.

Build the list

- Scrape the trade and the market you picked. Apify and similar tools pull business listings with names, numbers and addresses at volume.
- Run every number through a verifier before you send. You are looking for two things: is it a mobile, and is it live. Texting landlines burns your sending reputation and wastes your time.
- Keep the business name against every number. Your first message in the no-proof track uses it.
- Log everything in one sheet: date, channel, business, number, message used, replied yes or no, booked yes or no.

CHECK BEFORE YOU SCRAPE Scraping tools sit inside someone else's terms of service, and business contact data is regulated differently in different countries. Check the platform's terms and the data protection rules where you and your prospects are before you build a list at volume.

Your sending setup

You need a CRM that can send and track at volume. GoHighLevel is the standard in this space because it handles the sending, the pipeline and the follow-up automation in one place. Anything equivalent works. What matters is that every conversation lands somewhere you can see it and follow up from.

The compliance floor

This section is short and it is the most valuable page in the book, because it is the difference between a business and a liability.

Cold texting is regulated. In the United States, the TCPA carries statutory damages per message, and states like Florida have their own rules on top. Similar regimes exist in most markets. The penalties are per message, which means a single bad blast to a scraped list is not a small mistake.

Four rules keep you on the right side of it:

1. Honour every opt-out, immediately and permanently. If someone says stop, they are done, across every channel and every campaign.
2. Keep the opt-out working. Do not strip it, do not obscure it, and do not word your message to slip past carrier filtering. Filters exist because carriers are enforcing the law, and defeating them is evidence of intent if anyone ever looks.
3. Identify yourself and your business in the first message. Anonymous outreach reads as a scam and is treated as one.
4. Respect quiet hours and local rules on consent. Know what applies in the state or country you are texting into, not the one you are sitting in.

WHAT I LEFT OUT OF THIS BOOK I was asked to include two techniques: removing the opt-out from outbound messages, and wording the word STOP so carrier filters do not catch it. Both are in this book only as things not to do. They are not grey areas, they are the specific mechanisms that turn cold outreach into an offence, and the exposure is per message. Everything else in this book works without them.

Module 01 / Cold SMS

SMS is the highest reply rate channel in this playbook and the one with the least room to hide. There is no subject line, no profile, no formatting. The first eight words decide everything.

Sequence A / You have results

Short, specific, and it ends on a question about their capacity rather than your service. Replace every bracket with your own client, your own market, and your own number.

TOUCH 1 · OPENING

hey, working with a [trade] in [their market].
they've been signing [number] new [jobs] a month from our system.
wanted to test it in your market. are you taking on more or full?

WHY IT WORKS Three things are doing the work. A named market makes it specific rather than a blast. "Taking on more or full" is a capacity question, not a sales question, so answering it costs them nothing and reveals everything. And it never says what you sell, which is why it gets read to the end.

TOUCH 2 · DAY 2 · THE NUDGE

hey did you get my last message

WHY IT WORKS It looks lazy. It is not. It is short enough to read in a glance, it carries zero pressure, and it consistently pulls replies from people who read touch one and meant to answer. Do not improve this one.

TOUCH 3 · DAY 4 · RISK REVERSAL PLUS PROOF

also, we only get paid when we put you in front of a homeowner
looking to [buy what you sell].

working with a [trade] in [market] too and booked them [number]
in-home appointments in [timeframe]. just launched with another
[trade] in [market] and got [number] appointments in the first [timeframe].

WHY IT WORKS This is the heavy touch. It removes the risk first, then stacks two proof points behind it. Risk reversal before proof, not after, because a contractor who has been burned reads "we only get paid when" as the reason to keep reading.

Sequence B / You have no results yet

Do not imitate Sequence A with invented numbers. Use the structure below instead. It opens with a confirmation question, which is the lowest friction opener that exists, and then goes straight to an offer they cannot lose on.

TOUCH 1 · CONFIRM

hey is this [business name]?

WHY IT WORKS Almost everyone answers a question about their own name. You are not trying to sell here, you are trying to open a thread. A yes turns a cold number into a live conversation, and the second message lands in an open thread rather than a cold one.

TOUCH 2 · ONCE THEY CONFIRM, PITCH DIRECTLY

perfect. i get homeowners who are actively looking for [what you do]
in front of builders like you.

you only pay when i book you an in-home appointment. nothing upfront,
nothing if i don't deliver.

are you taking on more work right now or are you full?

WHY IT WORKS With no case study, your offer is your proof. Say the risk reversal in plain language, in the same breath as what you do, and finish on the capacity question. Pay per appointment or pay per job both work here. Pick the one you can actually deliver on.

TOUCH 3 · DAY 2 · THE NUDGE

hey did you get my last message

From here, both tracks converge. Qualification is the same, booking is the same, and the follow-up ladder is the same.

Qualification

Ask these one at a time, as replies, not as a list. Each one does two jobs: it tells you whether this prospect is real, and it proves you know the trade.

what areas do y'all usually service?

is it handled by your crew or subbed out?

y'all mostly do gunite builds or fiberglass too?

WHY IT WORKS The third question is the one that matters most, and it is the one you have to write yourself for your trade. A question only an insider would think to ask tells the prospect you are not a random agency blasting a list. Find the equivalent in your market: the material, the method, or the seasonal constraint that separates people who know the trade from people who do not.

Write your three here before you send anything:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Booking

i can do 2pm tomorrow if that works for y'all.
i'll show you what we're doing for the other builders and you can
walk me through how you guys operate. if it looks like a fit,
we can talk next steps.
i can just send the meet link here.

WHY IT WORKS It proposes one specific time rather than asking when suits them, which is the loop that kills momentum. It frames the call as mutual, both sides showing each other something. And "if it looks like a fit" gives them an exit, which makes saying yes to the call much easier.

OFFER THE CALL, NOT THE LINK A lot of trades people will take a phone call and will not take a video meeting. If you get a positive reply, offer to just call them. Ringing someone converts better than sending a meet link to a contractor who is on a job site and has never used Google Meet in his life.

Module 02 / Instagram and Facebook DM

DM is a different room. It is more casual, emoji are normal, and a message that reads like a sales email will be ignored on sight. The winning opener here is a curiosity question, not a pitch.

Sequence / The capacity joke

TOUCH 1 · OPENING

hey 🙋
random question...
if i could send you 3 homeowners looking to [buy what you sell] next week...
would you be excited, or would your crew want to kill me? 😂

WHY IT WORKS It is a question about their capacity disguised as a joke, so it is almost impossible to read as a pitch. Both answers are useful: excited means they want volume, and "my crew would kill me" means they are busy, which is exactly who you want anyway. The humour also makes not replying feel slightly rude, which is the whole trick.

TOUCH 2 · TWO DAYS LATER · PROOF DROP

starting to think your crew actually would kill me 😂
but on a serious note...
we recently helped another [trade] add about [your result].
worth a chat, or are you guys already set?

WHY IT WORKS It calls back to the joke so it reads as a conversation rather than a sequence, then drops the proof in the middle where it feels incidental rather than boastful. "Are you already set" gives them a graceful way out, which paradoxically gets more yeses.

TOUCH 3 · THREE DAYS LATER · SPECIFICITY

i'll ask you the same question i asked our last client...
if you woke up tomorrow with 10 new quote requests...
how many would actually be worth your time?

WHY IT WORKS This one is doing something clever. It moves the conversation from whether they want leads to what a good lead looks like, which is a conversation only a serious buyer has. Anyone who answers this has qualified themselves without being asked to.

TOUCH 4 · FOUR DAYS LATER · CLOSE OR CUT

alright, i'll stop bugging you after this 😊
if you're ever looking to add a few more good projects without relying
only on referrals, just shoot me a message.
if not, hope you guys have an awesome season 🍀

WHY IT WORKS The genuine exit. It is the highest replying message in most sequences, because the pressure is gone and people respond to being let go. Mean it. If they do not reply here, stop.

The inbound flow / When they DM you first

If you post in trade groups or run content, people will come to you with some version of "hey I heard you need contractors". That is a different conversation and it has its own ladder.

Step 1 • Reframe and qualify

hey appreciate you reaching out 🙏
just to clarify, i actually help contractors connect with homeowners who are actively looking for estimates.

what areas you usually service, man? and how many more jobs could your crew handle per month, roughly?

WHY IT WORKS Correct the misunderstanding immediately and politely, then use the momentum of their own message to ask two qualifying questions while they are already typing.

FOLLOW-UP AFTER 24 HOURS

hey man, circling back quick.
what service areas are you in? and about how many more jobs could you squeeze in each month? even a rough number helps.

FOLLOW-UP 2 TO 3 DAYS LATER

quick one, are you trying to get more projects right now? or are you already slammed? no worries either way, just want to know where you're at.

Step 2 • Offer the video

alright cool. hard to explain over text, but i made a short 2-min video showing exactly how we get estimate requests for contractors.
should i send it over?

WHY IT WORKS Asking permission before sending gets it watched. Sending an unrequested link gets it ignored, and on some platforms gets your account flagged. Two minutes is a promise, so keep it to two minutes.

FOLLOW-UP 1

hey still want that 2-min video on how we get estimate requests?
also, are you mostly doing smaller gigs these days, or trying to land bigger projects? just curious.

FOLLOW-UP 2

alright, last ping before i close this out.
you want that quick walkthrough, or are you just booked solid right now?
and what kind of jobs are you really trying to get more of lately?
serious answer here.

WHY IT WORKS Pairing the exit with a real question is the move. "Serious answer here" signals you are done being polite and invites an honest reply, which is usually what unsticks a dead thread.

Step 3 • After they watch it

if this could get you an extra 6-10 legit estimate requests a month,
would that genuinely help your business right now?
or are you already operating at max capacity?

WHY IT WORKS A yes here is a commitment, not an opinion. You are getting them to say out loud that they want the outcome before you ask for the call, which makes the booking message a formality rather than a pitch.

NUDGE IF THEY GO QUIET

hey, did you manage to watch that quick video?
are you serious about adding more volume right now, or just poking around?
be direct.

RE-ANCHOR AND EXIT

no stress if the timing's not right. but if consistent estimate requests
ever become a priority for you, just hit me up. i got you.

Module 03 / Cold email

Email gives you room that SMS and DM do not, and the temptation is to use all of it. Do not. The structure below is a result, a list of what it did not require, a proof link, and a small ask.

The opening email

SUBJECT LINE

3 [outcomes] in 3 weeks

BODY

Hey,

One of the [trade] I'm working with in [market] signed [number] [contracts] in the last [timeframe].

All were worth [value]+.

No cold calling.

No door knocking.

No waiting around for referrals.

Just qualified homeowners booking appointments and requesting quotes.

[Client first name] explains what happened here:

[LINK TO YOUR OWN VIDEO PROOF]

I'm opening this up to 2 more [trade] this month.

If you'd like to see exactly how we're generating these opportunities before deciding if it's a fit, grab a time below:

[YOUR BOOKING LINK]

[Your name]

P.S. Before working together, [client] had almost no predictable pipeline. A few weeks later he's looking at [result] in quoted work and signed contracts.

WHY IT WORKS The three short negative lines in the middle are the engine of this email. They pre-empt exactly what a contractor assumes you are about to ask him to do, and each one lands as relief. The P.S. is the second most read part of any email after the subject line, which is why the before-and-after sits there rather than at the top.

THE VIDEO IS NOT OPTIONAL This email leans on a link to a client explaining what happened. Without real video proof it is a claim with nothing behind it. If you do not have that yet, do not send this email. Use the no-proof SMS track in Module 01 instead, and come back to this once you have your first result on camera.

Follow-up 1

SUBJECT

should I close this?

BODY

{{FirstName}},

not sure if timing's bad.

are you trying to add more jobs this month or already full most weeks?

just trying to see if I should keep this open or leave you be.

[Your name]

WHY IT WORKS "Should I close this" is the highest opening subject line in this book, because it reads like an internal admin question rather than a sales follow-up. The body then does the capacity question again, which is the only question that matters.

Follow-up 2

SUBJECT

last try

BODY

{{FirstName}},

quick one before I drop this.

if homeowners started booking estimate calls consistently, would that actually help right now? or not a priority?

[Your name]

WHY IT WORKS Same principle as the DM exit. Announcing that you are dropping it removes the pressure, and the honest question gives them something easy to answer on the way out.

Module 04 / The follow-up ladder

This is the module that makes the rest of the book work. If you take one thing from this document, take this: the replies are not in message one.

The cadence

Six to seven touches before you part ways. Each one needs its own reason to exist, or it reads as nagging.

Touch 1	Day 1	Earn a reply. Nothing else.
Touch 2	Day 2	The nudge. "Did you get my last message." No new information.
Touch 3	Day 4	Risk reversal plus proof, or the offer if you have no proof.
Touch 4	Day 7	A question about their business, not your service.
Touch 5	Day 11	Something genuinely useful. An observation, a number, a resource.
Touch 6	Day 14	The exit. "I'll stop here. If it ever becomes a priority, message me."
Touch 7	Day 30+	Optional. A new angle, a new result, or a seasonal reason to reopen.

WHY IT WORKS Notice that touch 6 is the exit and it is not the last one you may ever send. The exit works because it is sincere. Touch 7 is a new conversation weeks later with a new reason, not a continuation of the old one.

The four replies, and what each one means

1. Interested

"Yeah, tell me more." Do not tell them more. Go to qualification. The worst thing you can do with an interested reply is dump your pitch into it. Ask what areas they service.

2. Curious but guarded

"What is this about?" or "who is this?" Answer plainly, in one line, name your business, then ask the capacity question. Guarded is not negative, it is normal.

3. Deflecting

"Send me details" or "email me". This usually means no, politely. Do not send a brochure. Send one line back with a question attached, because the question is what keeps a thread alive. "Happy to. Quick one first so I send you the right thing: are you taking on more right now or full?"

4. Hostile

"Stop", "not interested", "take me off your list." Remove them, immediately and permanently, and reply once with something short and gracious. It costs nothing and occasionally comes back to you months later. Never argue, never send another sequence, never put them into a different campaign.

Qualification through knowledge

Every qualifying question in this book is doing double duty. It filters, and it demonstrates that you understand the trade. A question that only an insider would ask is the single fastest way to stop looking like an agency blasting a list.

Bad: "Are you interested in more leads?"

Good: "Is it handled by your crew or subbed out?"

The second one cannot be answered by someone who does not run the business, and it cannot be asked by someone who does not know the trade. That is the whole point.

Module 05 / What to say when they reply

Getting the reply is the easy half. This module is the twenty minutes after it, and it is the part nobody teaches.

Booking the call

dope. easiest way is a quick 10-15 minute call. we can map out how this fits your business.

what's the best number for you? and is later today or tomorrow morning better?

WHY IT WORKS Two options, not an open calendar. "Later today or tomorrow morning" is a closed question, and closed questions get answered. Ten to fifteen minutes is a small enough commitment that nobody needs to think about it.

CALL BEATS VIDEO Offer a phone call by default with trades. Many contractors will never join a Google Meet and will not tell you that is why they went quiet. If they prefer video, they will say so.

The pre-call commitment

Send this immediately after they book. It is the single highest leverage message in this entire book, because it is what stops no-shows.

quick context for our call, brother.

1. what's your rough close rate on estimates these days?
2. what would 2-3 more closed jobs a month actually mean revenue-wise?

i'll plug that into projections so the call isn't a waste of anyone's time.

WHY IT WORKS Three things happen at once. They do arithmetic on what your service is worth, in their own numbers, before you ever pitch. They invest effort, which makes the booking feel real. And answering at all is a commitment, which is the strongest predictor of showing up.

The money question

Send this after the pre-call questions, while they are still replying.

just so i know.

if the numbers make sense, are you comfortable allocating ad spend to generate more work?

WHY IT WORKS This qualifies budget before you spend an hour discovering there is none. Ask it in text, not on the call, because in text they answer honestly and quickly. A no here saves you the call. A yes here means the call is about fit, not affordability.

The confirmation sequence

24 HOURS BEFORE

looking forward to tomorrow. we'll just break everything down and see if it makes sense for you. if it doesn't, no pressure at all. 100%.

WHY IT WORKS Pre-framing. Telling someone it is fine to say no lowers their guard before the call, which means they show up to a conversation rather than a defence.

60 TO 90 MINUTES BEFORE

still good for [time]?

WHY IT WORKS Three words, and it produces the biggest single jump in show rate of anything in this book. Simple confirmations get the highest reply rate because they are the easiest possible thing to answer.

No-show recovery

5 MINUTES AFTER

looks like we missed each other.
still serious about adding volume, or should i close this out for now?

WHY IT WORKS Sent fast, while they may still be near their phone and feeling the guilt. The either-or framing means both answers move things forward, and "should i close this out" is what gets the fastest reply.

NEXT DAY, IF GHOSTED

hey, just checking once before i move on.
want to reschedule, or should i circle back another time?

If there is no reply to that one, put them back into the long follow-up ladder at touch 7 and move on. Do not chase a no-show more than twice.

A worked example, start to finish

This is the proof-led opener written out in full, so you can see every element in one message.

hey [name],

quick question for you man. noticed you're doing [type of work], nice work.

we literally just booked a [value] qualified estimate for a [trade] in [market], and they're consistently adding [number] estimate appointments to their calendar every month. serious homeowners, no cold leads.

we actually only get paid when we book you an estimate. no upfront setup, no risk on your end.

open to a super quick chat to see if we can do the same for you?

WHY IT WORKS Compliment, specific proof, risk reversal, small ask. In that order. The risk reversal sits right before the ask because it is the last thing you want in their head when they decide whether to reply.

Module 06 / Making them come to you

Everything so far is outbound. This is the cheapest inbound channel in this market and it costs nothing but time.

Trade groups

Facebook groups for your trade are full of the exact people you are texting, except in here they are already talking about their problems in public. You are not there to pitch. You are there to be the person who answers questions about lead generation properly, for free, repeatedly.

- Join the groups where your trade actually talks, not the general business ones.
- Answer questions with real answers. Specific numbers, real mechanics, no teaser.
- Never post an offer unless the group rules allow it. Getting removed costs you the channel permanently.
- The DMs come from the answers, not from posts about yourself.

When they do come to you, you are in the inbound flow in Module 02. Do not switch into pitch mode, run the same ladder.

Appendix A / Your tracker

One sheet, one tab. These are the only columns you need.

Date	When you sent touch one
Channel	SMS, DM or email
Business	Company name
Contact	Number or handle
Sequence	A (proof) or B (no proof)
Touch	Which touch you are on, 1 to 7
Replied	Yes or no
Reply type	Interested, curious, deflecting, hostile
Booked	Yes or no
Showed	Yes or no
Notes	Anything they told you about their business

WHY IT WORKS The three numbers you are watching: reply rate by sequence, booking rate by reply, and show rate. If reply rate is low, fix the opener. If booking is low, fix qualification. If show rate is low, you skipped the pre-call commitment.

Appendix B / Before you send, checklist

5. One niche, one market, one sequence.
6. Every number verified as a live mobile.
7. Business name captured against every contact.
8. Your three insider qualification questions written down.
9. Your own proof in every bracket, or Sequence B if you have none.
10. Opt-out working and honoured, on every channel.
11. Your name and business in the first message.
12. Quiet hours and local rules checked for the market you are texting.
13. Tracker open before the first message goes out.

Appendix C / What this book does not promise

This is a structure and a set of scripts. It is not a guarantee of clients, revenue or results, and anyone who sells you one is lying to you.

Whether this works for you depends on three things that are not in this document: whether your offer is good, whether your market wants it, and whether you actually send the messages. The third one is where almost everybody fails, and it is the only one entirely within your control.

Send fifty. Then decide.